

Zulia Shavaeva

Senior GenAI Security Consultant, AWS Generative AI Innovation Center. EMEA security lead.

Summary

I am the security lead for AWS's Generative AI Innovation Center across EMEA, the security authority on every GenAI engagement in the region. I have eight years in engineering, DevOps and security for regulated enterprises, the last five dedicated to security, with 45 or more engagement security assessments across banks, insurers, automotive finance, pharma, energy and public sector in the UK, EU, Middle East and Africa. My specialisms are EU data residency, Zero Data Retention, GDPR and DPIA-aligned data classification, and agentic AI security, including MCP and autonomous agents.

Selected work

Co-author of AWS's security model for forward-deployed, agentic AI engineering, built for teams whose agents ship code faster than humans can gate: in-pod scanning against agentic threat classes such as excessive agency, tool misuse and privilege chains, oversight of production access without holding any, and a 45-minute co-signed security kickoff replacing multi-week reviews.

Author of a GenAI security capture-the-flag spanning prompt injection chains, guardrail bypass and data exfiltration via tool-use, selected for AWS re:Invent 2026 GameDay. I built LLM guardrails tooling hands-on, including a prompt-safety gate and a programmatic PII sanitiser.

Featured in BBC News coverage of women in computing, and winner of the Professor Sue Black Award for Technology Evangelism. Top 10 content contributor across AWS Professional Services globally, with 10,000 or more views.

Experience

- EMEA Security Lead, Generative AI Innovation Center Dec 2025, present
Amazon Web Services, Professional Services

- Security authority for all GenAI engagements across EMEA, owning the security review function end to end and leading security design for AWS's forward-deployed AI engineering model.
- Advise regulated customers on secure frontier-model deployment, including Claude via the AWS-Anthropic partnership, on data retention and Zero Data Retention, EU data residency including cross-region inference boundaries, encryption, guardrails and audit logging. Caught a cross-region inference profile silently breaking a European airline group's EU-residency claim, corrected their AI-governance submission and presented the security architecture to their governance board.
- Secured multi-year follow-on contracts by resolving security blockers in pre-sales for major European banks, automotive groups and Middle East enterprises, using risk-based exceptions with compensating controls, synthetic-data strategies and security architectures that passed customer risk review first time.
- Approver for prohibited and high-risk AI use-case assessments across EMEA under EU AI Act-aligned risk triage. I help develop the organisation's EU AI Act guidance and lead the region's GDPR and DPIA-aligned data classification and risk-acceptance process, escalating to Director and VP level.
- Built the organisation's security operations dashboard, covering 2,600 or more reviews across seven global geographies, and a security onboarding knowledgebase, both adopted as team standard. I run standing EMEA security office hours and deliver security workshops to customer-facing teams.

● Senior Security Consultant, Generative AI Innovation Center 2024, Dec 2025

Amazon Web Services, Professional Services

- Vendor due diligence for financial services: led a large asset manager's 104-question enterprise security review of an AI deployment, authoring the AI, GenAI and model-risk sections, including operational-resilience questions on SLAs and RTO/RPO that DORA and NIS2 now drive.
- Agentic AI security: security reviews of MCP-based and autonomous-agent systems, including Amazon Bedrock AgentCore applications and agent frameworks. Held the line on critical findings and closed engagements clean, refusing approval on unauthenticated PII exposure in a customer-facing agent system until fixed, and defending a critical severity deserialization finding against customer pushback until the customer accepted it.

● Security, Risk & Compliance Consultant 2022, 2024

Amazon Web Services

- Led security workstreams on AWS's most strategic EMEA programmes, including publicly referenced programmes for banks, exchanges, airlines and consumer brands: secure migrations, regulatory alignment and resilience uplift.
- Designed enterprise AWS security frameworks and reference architectures, including IAM baselines, KMS and encryption strategy, secure landing zones, monitoring standards and incident response playbooks passing ISO 27001, NIST CSF and PCI DSS audits first time.
- Implemented Zero Trust architectures with least-privilege IAM, just-in-time access and elimination of standing privilege. Hardened EKS estates with image scanning, admission control and runtime monitoring for regulated workloads, plus SIEM and SOAR integration and tabletop exercises.
- Executive advisory: trusted advisor to C-suite and boards, shaping security strategy and influencing multi-million-dollar contracts.

● Earlier roles 2018, 2022

- DevOps Consultant, AWS (2020 to 2022): CI/CD and infrastructure automation with Lambda, Terraform and CDK, then promoted into the security specialism.
- Algorithms and Data Structures Instructor, Durham University.

- Software Engineer, Nissan Trading Corporation, building a manufacturing scheduling optimisation that saved over £1 million within six months, and secure REST APIs with OAuth 2.0 and JWT.

Expertise

Frontier-model deployment security

Zero Data Retention

EU AI Act readiness

Agentic AI and MCP security

Bedrock Guardrails

GDPR and DPIA data classification

EU data residency

IAM and Zero Trust

KMS and encryption

EKS and container security

SIEM and SOAR

ISO 27001, NIST CSF, PCI DSS

DORA and NIS2 readiness

CISO and board advisory

Certifications

AWS Certified Security, Specialty

AWS Certified Solutions Architect, Professional

AWS Certified Developer, Associate

AWS Certified DevOps Engineer, Associate

CCSP (ISC²), in progress

Education

BSc Computer Science, Durham University

Languages

English, fluent

Russian, native

Community

Lead, AWS Cloud Women Manchester, the largest AWS Cloud Women chapter in the UK